PROJECT 3: Professional Portfolio Website

CAPSTONE PROJECT

Project Type: Capstone Individual Project **Points:** 30 points	**Due Date:** May 4, 2026 **Submit:** ZIP file (HTML, CSS, images, docs, design-process)

Project Overview

Build a complete professional portfolio website showcasing your work from this course and beyond. This is your capstone project and should demonstrate everything you have learned throughout the semester. Your portfolio will serve as your professional calling card and showcase your skills to potential employers or clients.

This portfolio must be deployed to a live URL and represent your absolute best work. Think of this as the project that could land you your dream job or internship.

Learning Objectives

- Synthesize all skills learned throughout the semester
- Create a professional portfolio ready for job applications
- Master the complete design-to-deployment workflow
- Develop professional copywriting and presentation skills
- Implement advanced interactions and animations
- Deploy and maintain a live website

Project Requirements

1. Complete Design Process (Required)

Hand Sketches (Required)

- Create hand-drawn sketches showing your overall site layout for each page
- Sketch navigation, major content areas, and page structure
- Show how pages relate to each other
- Take clear photos of your sketches and place them in `assets/design-process/sketches/`

2. Required Pages (Minimum 5 Pages)

Page 1: Homepage (Required)

- Strong hero section introducing yourself
- Brief overview of your skills or focus areas
- Featured projects or work samples
- Clear navigation to other sections
- Call-to-action (contact, view work, etc.)

Page 2: About (Required)

- Professional biography (150 to 300 words)
- Professional headshot or photo
- Skills, technologies, or tools you work with
- Education and relevant experience
- What makes you unique or your design philosophy

Page 3: Work or Projects (Required)

- Grid or gallery of projects
- Showcase at least 3 projects (from this class or beyond)
- Each project should have a thumbnail image and title
- Brief description or tag line for each
- Link to individual project case study pages

Page 4-6: Individual Project Case Studies (Minimum 3 Required)

- Project title and overview
- Challenge or problem statement
- Your role and responsibilities
- Final solution with screenshots or images
- Results or outcomes (what was the impact?)
- Reflection: what you learned
- Link to live project

Page 7: Contact (Required)

- Clear call-to-action encouraging contact
- Email address or contact form
- Social media links (LinkedIn, GitHub, etc.)
- Optional: Resume download link

3. Technical Requirements

HTML & Structure:

- Semantic HTML5 throughout entire site
- Consistent navigation across all pages
- Clean, organized code with comments
- Valid HTML (no errors)

CSS & Layout:

- Advanced layout techniques (CSS Grid, Flexbox)

- Custom CSS with design system (variables, consistent spacing)
- Professional typography system
- Cohesive visual design throughout

Animations & Interactions:

- Smooth page transitions or scroll animations
- Interactive hover states on links and buttons
- Fade-in, slide-in, etc. animations for content
- Subtle, professional animations (not overwhelming)

Responsive Design:

- Desktop-first approach (design for desktop, then scale down)
- Two breakpoints: Tablet (768px) and Mobile (480px)
- All pages should be functional and readable at all sizes
- Navigation should adapt on smaller screens (Hamburger menu)
- Images and media should scale properly and not overflow their containers

Accessibility:

- Descriptive alt text for all images
- Excellent color contrast (WCAG AA standard)
- Keyboard navigation support
- Semantic HTML for screen readers
- Lighthouse accessibility score of 95+ required

SEO Optimization:

- Unique title tags and meta descriptions for all pages
- Open Graph tags for social sharing
- Clean, descriptive URLs

Performance:

- Optimized images (compressed, proper sizes)
- Fast loading times (under 2 seconds)
- Lazy loading for images
- Lighthouse performance score of 85+ required

4. Deployment Requirements (REQUIRED)

Your portfolio MUST be deployed to a live URL. Choose ONE option:

Option 1: GitHub Pages (Free, Recommended)

- Create GitHub repository for your portfolio
- Enable GitHub Pages in repository settings
- URL format: username.github.io/portfolio

Option 2: Netlify or Vercel (Free, Easy)

- Sign up for free account
- Deploy directly from GitHub or upload files

- Get automatic HTTPS

Option 3: Custom Domain (Optional but Encouraged)

- Purchase custom domain (e.g., yourname.com)
- Connect to GitHub Pages, Netlify, or Vercel
- More professional and memorable

5. Professional Content Requirements

Copywriting:

- Professional, polished writing throughout
- No spelling or grammar errors
- Clear, concise descriptions
- Compelling case studies that tell a story

Photography and Graphics:

- Professional headshot or photo
- High-quality project images and screenshots
- Consistent visual style throughout
- Properly credited images if using stock photos

File Requirements & Submission

What to Submit:

```
LastName_Project3/
    index.html    (your landing page)
    about.html    (who you are)
    work.html     (all your projects)
    contact.html (get in touch)
    case-studies/
        project-one.html
        project-two.html
        project-three.html
    assets/
        css/
            style.css    (all your styles)
        images/
            hero/
            projects/
            profile/
        design-process/
            sketches/    (hand drawn sketches)
    deployment-info.txt (your live URL)
    README.txt    (project documentation)
```

File Naming:

`LastName_Project3.zip`

Example: `Kraishan_Project3.zip`

Grading Rubric (30 points total)

Criteria	Points	What I'm Looking For
Design Process & Sketches	3	1 sketch for each page. Clear, thoughtful hand sketches showing layout planning for your pages. Sketches demonstrate planning of navigation, content areas, and page hierarchy.
Visual Design & Branding	5	Outstanding visual design. Cohesive brand identity. Professional typography. Excellent color palette. Portfolio-quality aesthetics.
Technical Implementation	5	Advanced layouts (Grid, Flexbox). Clean, organized code. Smooth animations. Professional interactions. Modern CSS techniques.
Content & Case Studies	5	Professional copywriting. Compelling about page. 3+ detailed case studies with process and outcomes. High-quality images.
Responsive Design	4	Desktop-first approach. Layout adjusts at tablet (768px) and mobile (480px) breakpoints. Content readable and functional at all sizes. Images and media scale properly.
Accessibility	4	Descriptive alt text on all images. Sufficient color contrast. Semantic HTML throughout. ARIA attributes where needed. Visible :focus styles for keyboard navigation. lang attribute on <html>. Logical tab order.
Deployment & Performance	4	Successfully deployed to live URL. Fast loading. Optimized images. Lighthouse performance 85+. SEO optimization.

Portfolio Best Practices

Writing Effective Case Studies

Structure Each Case Study:

1. Project Overview: What is it? Brief summary.
2. Challenge: What problem were you solving?
3. Your Role: What were your responsibilities?
4. Process: Show sketches, wireframes, iterations
5. Solution: Final design with screenshots
6. Results: Impact, feedback, or outcomes

7. Reflection: What did you learn?

Homepage Tips

Hero Section:

- Strong headline that says who you are and what you do
- Examples: "Product Designer crafting user-centered experiences"
- "Web Designer building fast, accessible websites"
- Include clear call-to-action (View Work, Contact Me)

Deployment Guide

GitHub Pages (Recommended)

Step-by-Step:

1. Create GitHub account if you do not have one
2. Create new repository named: username.github.io
3. Upload your portfolio files (or push from command line)
4. Go to Settings, scroll to GitHub Pages
5. Select main branch as source
6. Your site will be live at username.github.io

Tips for Success

Start Early:

- This is a large project. Start immediately!
- Work on it consistently rather than cramming at the end

Get Feedback:

- Show your work-in-progress in office hours
- Ask classmates, friends, or family for feedback
- Test your portfolio on multiple devices

Polish Everything:

- This represents you professionally
- Check for typos, broken links, missing images
- Make sure everything works perfectly

Helpful Resources

Inspiration:

- BestFolios (Bestfolios.com) – Portfolio gallery
- Cofolios (cofolios.com) – Portfolio gallery
- Dribbble (dribbble.com) – Website Design Inspiration

- Behance (behance.net) – Website Design Inspiration
- Landbook (land-book.com) – Website Design Inspiration

Tools:

- TinyPNG/Squoosh - Image compression (https://squoosh.app/)
- Google Lighthouse - Performance testing (Google Chrome > Inspect > Lighthouse)
- W3C Validator - CSS validation (https://jigsaw.w3.org/css-validator/)
- W3C Validator - HTML validation (https://validator.w3.org/)

Deployment:

- GitHub Pages Documentation (docs.github.com)
- Netlify Documentation (docs.netlify.com)
- Vercel Documentation (vercel.com/docs)

Need Help?

Office Hours: Tuesday & Thursday 2:00 PM to 3:30 PM
Email: omareikr@ttu.edu

Why This Project Matters

This is not just a class project. This is your professional portfolio that you will use to:

- Apply for jobs and internships
- Showcase your skills to potential employers
- Attract freelance clients
- Build your professional brand
- Stand out in the competitive job market

IMPORTANT REMINDER

This portfolio is your professional calling card. Make it count! The quality of this project directly impacts your career opportunities. Employers will look at your portfolio when considering you for positions. Put in the time and effort to make it exceptional.